



Sealed, Then Re-Worn

Time to Successor Desire Line Across 96 Verge Shortcuts Formalised Under a Council Wear-Score Warrant

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The problem

A council seals a worn shortcut once its wear score holds above threshold across a 26-week observation window. The warrant treats sealing as resolution. Little is known about what forms beside a shortcut after it is sealed, or how soon.

Research questions

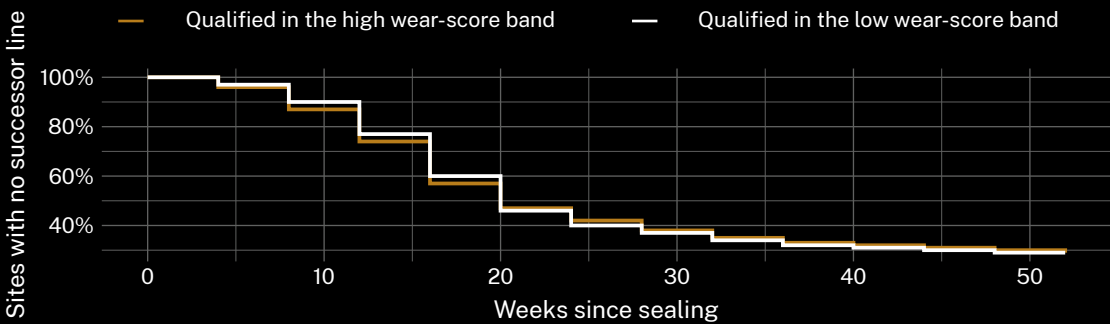
- Time from sealing to the emergence of a successor worn line.
- Whether the qualifying wear score predicts that timing.
- Observed recurrence against the warrant’s own qualification window.

Study design

- 96 sealed verge shortcuts · six wards · fortnightly rectified aerial tiles + ground wear survey · 14 months (Mar 2025 – May 2026).
- Successor pre-registered as a contiguous bare-earth line ≥ 1.5 m long and ≥ 30 cm mean width, persisting across three consecutive surveys.
- Kaplan–Meier survival; Cox proportional hazards on qualifying wear-score band. Coders blind to band; no threshold amended in-study.

What we found

Successor lines are common and early: 71% of sealed shortcuts carry one within twelve months, at a median of 18 weeks. The score that qualified a route shows no detectable association with how long its replacement takes.



Successor-free survival by qualifying wear-score band, 96 sealed shortcuts, March 2025 to May 2026. Median time to successor is 18 weeks in the high band and 19 in the low; the curves are indistinguishable (HR 1.04, 95% CI 0.71–1.52).

Interpretation & where next

Formalisation appears to relocate a route rather than close it. Because the warrant’s 26-week qualification window exceeds the observed median recurrence interval, a successor is typically established before its predecessor’s file is closed — consistent with the unresolved-routes register rising in every month of the study period. The instrument measures wear faithfully; on these data it is the cadence, not the measurement, that does not appear to converge. Next: a warrant variant that qualifies the corner rather than the line.

Selected references

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Surveys conducted from public land; no property boundaries surveyed and no residents approached. Successor definition and wear-score bands were pre-registered before the first survey; none was amended.

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“The successor line opens at a median of 18 weeks. The warrant needs 26 to qualify one.”

71% of sealed shortcuts carried a fresh worn line within twelve months, and the register of unresolved informal routes did not fall in any month of the study period.